

Dramatic Purpose

The Techniques of Drama

To hold the attention of an audience and provoke a progressively strong emotional response within a short period of time, a dramatist must meticulously structure a play. Every conversation, soliloquy, and action must serve a purpose in the unfolding drama. This is known as dramatic purpose, a term applied to the importance a scene or speech has in fulfilling a writer's objective.

What follows is a list of dramatic purposes a dramatist may have for a conversation, soliloquy, or incident, and may even include a whole scene in a play. The dramatic purpose may be to

- a. advance the **plot** (to start the conflict; depict the victories and defeats of the protagonist; depict some incident or decision that will precipitate further events in the conflict)
- b. indicate **setting**
- c. provide **exposition**
- d. develop **character** (to reveal the nature of a person)
- e. show **parallels** between characters and plot of a previous or forthcoming scene
- f. create **atmosphere** and impart **mood**
- g. develop **theme**
- h. create **suspense**
- i. create **dramatic irony** (and heighten **tension**)
- j. provide **dramatic relief** (to break tension after a particularly dramatic or tense scene)
- k. provide **comic relief** (a type of dramatic relief, comic relief relieves tension by provoking laughter from the audience)
- l. **foreshadow** coming events
- m. **arouse emotion** in the audience (to deliberately make the audience's sympathies lie where the dramatists wants them to lie, e.g. to create pathos; it may direct the audience's sympathies toward a certain character, or withdraw sympathy from a character)

Note that a conversation, soliloquy, or incident may have more than one dramatic purpose.